

Why Congress Won

NOVEMBER 2, 2009

Sonia consolidates the party's hold on national politics with a hat-trick in Maharashtra and defeating opponents in Arunachal Pradesh and Haryana.



“It is clear that the Congress won Maharashtra and Haryana because of the fragmented opposition. What is worrying is the emergence of Raj Thackeray and non-stop slide of the BJP.”

BAL GOVIND, Noida

Not a Big Hand

You are right in saying that “apart from Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Delhi, Congress is not in power in any of the big states” (“The Winning Hand”, November 2). If the BJP had aligned with Om Prakash Chautala in Haryana, the Congress would have surely lost. Similarly, had the MNS been handled diplomatically by the Shiv Sena or BJP, things would have been different in Maharashtra. The masses have realised that it is better to bring a more acceptable leadership to power rather than voting for pygmies. Sonia Gandhi's greatest asset is the family she is wedded into and that is one of the reasons why she is considered the best among the worst. H.C. PANDEY, Delhi

Will the Congress in an alliance with the NCP in

For God's Sake

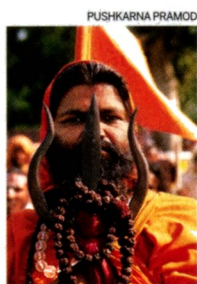
Chandan Mitra, in his review of my book *The God Market*, clearly doesn't like what I have to say (“Divine Comedy”, October 26). So in the fine tradition of apologists, he calls me a *desh drohi* (“Meera Nanda doesn't like India”) and a *dharm virodhi* to boot (“she hates popular Hinduism with even greater passion”). Although Mitra dislikes my attitude, he concedes almost everything that I argue in the book. He describes as “surreptitious” the “manner in which Hindu ideas have crept into state policy, educational institutions, temple trusts and even civil society perceptions”. I couldn't have put it better myself. Nearly every fact

in the book is backed by the best possible evidence available in the public domain. For the most part, Mitra doesn't question the evidence. But the only place he does, he displays a wilful disregard of basic social science meth-

ods. He takes a jab at the data from the Global Attitudes Survey that the US-based Pew Research Center carried out in 2007 that I cite in the book. He casts doubt at

their methodology, forgetting the statistical science of drawing a random sample which even though small (merely 2,043 respondents) can be representative of the larger urban population. When we agree to disagree, it is better to disagree rationally.

MEERA NANDA



PUSHKARNA PRAMOD

Maharashtra let us know how it won so comfortably in that state despite non-performance? Farmers in Vidarbha continue to commit suicide, lakhs of people are still living in Mumbai slums in horrible conditions, there is a power shortage and land encroachment by private builders, essential commodities are priced abnormally, terrorism shows no signs of being vanquished. The Congress won because of the disarray in the Opposition which resulted in division of votes in favour of the party and not because it deserved to win.

A. SRIKANTIAH, Bangalore

It has been rightly observed that having advanced the assembly elections by about six months, after winning nine of the 10 seats in the Lok Sabha elections, Haryana

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